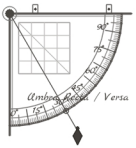
Field Log: The Desert Frontier

Autumn, 1998 — Twenty-eight years before the Call.

I. The First Crossing into the Red Sands

I was twenty-four when I left the Sanctuary library behind, carrying only my brass quadrant, unfinished star plates, and the elder's forbidden charts. The scholars believed the desert was a barren waste of dead stone. They could not understand that the sand is the purest mirror of the cosmos; here the flat horizon allows the curvature of the earth to be weighed directly.



Surveyor's Altitude Quadrant (90°)
Polaris Alt. Reading: 30° 00′ N

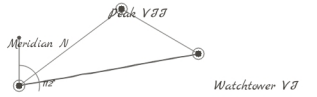
II. Astronomy of the Dunes

For fourteen nights, I measured the altitude of Polaris from the dry ridge. At local midnight, the north star hangs fixed at thirty degrees above the horizon, anchoring the great turning vault of the night sky. By calculating the sun's meridian shadow at noon, I confirmed what was written: this latitude is no accident. It marks the fourth harmonic of the astrolabe.

III. The Three Cairns & The Copper Benchmark

Before ascending to Outer Watchtower VI, I surveyed the dry wash bed below. To mark the route for the seeker who would one day follow my footsteps, I raised three stone cairns along the canyon wash, pointing south-southeast. Beneath the foundation stones of Cairn III, beneath a flat red sandstone slab, I buried the first copper benchmark plate engraved with the bearing of 112 degrees.

Geodetic Triangulation Study



Station 0 (Wash)
Base Baseline: 5,420 paces to Red Ridge
Watchtower VI Bearing: 112° East
Magnetic Offset: +04° 15′ (True N. Corr.)
Apex Elevation (Peak VIII): 1,240 varas



The Cartographer